

Amazon: Company History

Amazon was founded by Jeff Bezos in Bellevue, Washington, on 5 July 1994. Originally named Cadabra (as in abracadabra), Bezos renamed it Amazon after the Amazon River and incorporated the company on 28 July 1994. The site went live in July 1995.

Amazon's first product was books. The first book sold was "Fluid Concepts and Creative Analogies" by Douglas Hofstadter, shipped in April 1995. Amazon went public on 15 May 1997 at USD 18 per share.

Amazon expanded into music in 1998, into consumer electronics and toys in 1999, and into a general marketplace in 2000. Amazon Prime launched in February 2005 at USD 79 per year. Amazon Web Services (AWS), launched in March 2006, pioneered cloud infrastructure and became Amazon's most profitable segment.

Jeff Bezos stepped down as CEO on 5 July 2021, succeeded by Andy Jassy, the former head of AWS. Bezos became Executive Chairman. In 2013 Bezos purchased The Washington Post for USD 250 million.

Amazon acquired Whole Foods Market in 2017 for USD 13.4 billion, MGM Studios in 2021 for USD 8.5 billion, and iRobot in 2024 (after regulatory concessions).